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LITRES

THE AMOUNT OF WATER IT TAKES TO MAKE A SINGLE PAIR OF JEANS, STARTING FROM PRODUCTION OF COTTON TO ITS RETAIL DELIVERY. THAT'S ENOUGH WATER TO SUSTAIN A FAMILY OF FOUR LIVING IN A DROUGHT-AFFECTED AFRICAN NATION FOR MORE THAN A YEAR

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WHEN 36-YEAR-OLD Sujata Biswas and her sister Taniya quit their corporate jobs in 2016, little did they know that they were on the path to starting one of the most successful sustainable clothing brands in India, which today has an annual turnover of ₹50 crore. Suta, a combination of their initials—which means thread in Sanskrit—was born out of their love for sarees, and sustainable daily habits. “Sustainability is a part of how we grew up. Our mother would get fabric from artisans and stitch clothes herself. As a family we never over-consumed, and practised such a lifestyle even before we knew it was called sustainability,” says Sujata Biswas, Co-founder of Suta.

For Biswas, sustainability is a process and not the destination. In a country where more than 1 million tonne of textiles are discarded every year, brands like Suta are more than a necessity. According to a 2019 McKinsey report, India is set to become one of the most attractive markets for apparel with more than 300 international fashion brands expected

to open stores here by 2022-23. This can't be good news from a sustainability perspective since the fashion industry is considered to be the second-biggest consumer of water, according to the UN Environment Programme. For instance, consider the pair of jeans you're wearing. It takes 3,781 litres of water to make a single pair of jeans, starting from production of cotton to its retail delivery. That's enough water to sustain a family of four living in a drought-affected African nation for more than a year.

Mumbai-based Suta is not only moving towards ethical production, but also employing more than 16,000 local weavers and artisans across the country from Uttar Pradesh to Odisha, and from Kashmir to Tamil Nadu. “It's not just about a sustainable product, but a process. It's about hiring local [talent], treating them well, getting office spaces with more natural sunlight, upcycling, nurturing animals affected by a fast-fashion cycle, etc.,” Biswas explains.

Like Suta, many other start-ups are exploring ways to make a difference in the fashion industry. According to a report by the Indian Chamber of Commerce (ICC), domestic demand for fashion fuelled by the rising income of middle-class consumers is growing exponentially. “Per capita expenditure on apparel is expected to reach ₹6,400 by 2023, from ₹3,900 in 2018,” the report states.

International fast-fashion brands such as Zara, H&M, and Marks &